

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN OMAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community effort in Oman has a distinctive character, because Oman is a stable, consultative Sultanate where the ultimate power rests with the Sultan and the Royal Court, and there is a sobering precedent this guide places at its center. In 2007, Oman's **Arabian Oryx Sanctuary** — a vast desert reserve that had been one of the world's great conservation successes, home to the first free-ranging herd of Arabian oryx anywhere on earth since the species was hunted to extinction in the wild in 1972 — became the first site ever to be removed from the UNESCO World Heritage List, after the Sultanate reduced the protected area by a full ninety percent, by royal decree, to allow oil and gas exploration; the oryx population fell from four hundred and fifty in 1996 to just sixty-five. This is the honest starting point for any effort in Oman: the state, when it chooses, can and will override even its own celebrated conservation and its international heritage status for oil, and it does so from the top, with little domestic voice. This guide will not pretend that a community can easily overturn such a decision; it cannot. But the levers, though limited, are real.

A community in Oman works not through protest or confrontation, which have little place here, but respectfully within the system, appealing to its better commitments — and the tools, though limited, are real. The **consultative councils** — the elected Majlis al-Shura and the municipal councils — are real, if advisory, channels to raise concerns and influence policy. The **traditional governance** — the wali system and the tribal sheikhs — are respected intermediaries with standing to carry a community's concerns upward. Major projects must reckon with **environmental impact assessment and Oman's environmental law**, a formal gate. The **heritage-and-values appeal** — the Sultanate's own celebrated commitment to conservation, heritage, and its national vision — is a lever a community can invoke, though, as the oryx shows, with honest limits. And the **international and UNESCO attention** the image-conscious Sultanate cares about is a real reputational channel. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The state decides from the top: the oryx sanctuary was cut by royal decree despite Oman's conservation reputation and its World Heritage status, because oil was found beneath it — a plain demonstration that the appeal to the state's own commitments, real as they are, can be overridden when the stakes are high enough. Oman has no political parties, little independent civil society, and no culture of public protest; the consultative councils advise but do not command; and the ultimate power over every such decision is the Sultan's alone. So the work must be respectful, within the system, consultative, and appealing to the state's own values and image — never confrontational — and the honest prize is a harmful project raised through the councils and the traditional channels, assessed, reconsidered, or improved, and the state's own heritage and image invoked, not a decision overturned from below. In Oman, one works respectfully within the system and appeals to its better commitments.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot overturn a decision from below in a Sultanate where the ultimate power is the Sultan's, and you do not confront, for confrontation has no place here. What you can do is work respectfully within the system and appeal to its better commitments: raise the concern through the consultative councils and the traditional wali and tribal channels; hold the project to its environmental assessment; invoke the Sultanate's own celebrated commitment to conservation and heritage; and engage the international and UNESCO attention an image-conscious state cares about — all respectfully, and with honest expectations.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Oman is a stable, top-down Sultanate, and honesty about that is the first discipline — the oryx sanctuary makes it plain. The state decides from the top and will override even its own conservation for oil; there are no political parties, little civil society, and no protest culture; the councils advise but do not command; and the ultimate power is the Sultan's. So the realistic aim is not to overturn a decision from below but to raise a harmful project respectfully through the councils and traditional channels, to have it assessed, reconsidered, or improved, and to invoke the state's own heritage and image — working within the system, and with honest expectations.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Ultimate power in Oman rests with the **Sultan and the Royal Court**, who decide the great questions from the top. Below them, the **ministries and the environment authority** administer the assessments, permits, and environmental law. The **Majlis al-Shura and the municipal councils** advise. The **walis and tribal sheikhs** carry community concerns upward through the traditional channels. And the **UNESCO and international bodies** hold the reputational attention the Sultanate values. Map who decides, and through which respectful channel a concern can reach them, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A major project moves through the ministries and the environmental assessment, and — for the great decisions — the Royal Court from the top. You enter respectfully: through the consultative councils and the traditional wali and tribal channels, which can carry a concern upward; through the environmental assessment; through the appeal to the Sultanate's own heritage and values; and through the international and UNESCO attention. Enter within the system, respectfully, and with honest expectations of what the councils can and cannot command.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the decision: whether a project is a ministry matter or a great question decided from the top, as the oryx sanctuary was. Follow the assessment: whether the environmental study and law were properly met. Follow the values: which of the Sultanate's own conservation and heritage commitments the project strains. Follow the image: whether the international and UNESCO attention the Sultanate cares about is engaged. The leverage lies in the consultative and traditional channels, the assessment, the heritage appeal, and the international attention.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here are the ministries and environment authority, the advisory Majlis al-Shura and municipal councils, the traditional walis and tribal sheikhs, and — internationally — UNESCO and the bodies whose attention the Sultanate values. The honest caution, written by the oryx, is that all of these can be overridden from the top; so a case engages them respectfully, appealing to the state's better commitments and its image.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Omani community easily overturns a decision made from the top, and honesty requires saying so — the oryx sanctuary is the proof. What the respectful, within-system tools can deliver is a harmful project raised, assessed, reconsidered, or improved, and the state's own values and image invoked. The single most decisive move is **raising the concern respectfully through the consultative and traditional channels while invoking the Sultanate's own heritage and international image**, because these are the avenues the system provides, and because an image-conscious state that prizes its conservation reputation is sensitive to being seen to betray it. The consultative and traditional channels are the distinctive levers; the assessment the formal gate; the heritage appeal and international attention the pressure — all with the honest limit that the top can override. The realistic prize is influence, not overturning.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the project threatening the desert, coast, water, or a protected place. **Who decides it?** — a ministry, or the top, as with the oryx. **What does it need?** — an environmental assessment under Oman's law. **Which value does it strain?** — the Sultanate's own conservation, heritage, or national vision. **Which respectful channel reaches it?** — the councils, the wali, the tribal sheikhs, the international attention. Pick the fight where the consultative and traditional channels and the heritage appeal give the clearest, most respectful handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers, respectfully. **Layer one: the harm** — the desert, coast, water, or protected place at stake, documented with the science. **Layer two: the assessment and the value** — the environmental assessment and law, and the Sultanate's own conservation, heritage, and national-vision commitments the project strains. **Layer three: the channel and the image** — the consultative councils, walis, and tribal sheikhs to engage, and the international and UNESCO attention to invoke. A case grounded in the assessment and the state's own values, raised respectfully, is one the system can receive — with the honest limit that the top may still decide otherwise.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the project's plans and footprint, the desert, coast, water, or protected place at stake, the science. Gather the **assessment record**: the environmental assessment and Oman's environmental law. Gather the **values record**: the Sultanate's own conservation, heritage, and national-vision commitments. Gather the **channel record**: the Majlis al-Shura and municipal councils, the walis and tribal sheikhs, the international and UNESCO bodies. Much of the values and heritage record is public and can be respectfully invoked.

STEP 3: BUILDING SUPPORT THROUGH THE CONSULTATIVE AND TRADITIONAL CHANNELS

In a Sultanate with no protest culture, the effort is consultative and traditional, not confrontational. Build with the **affected community**, whose concern must be carried respectfully; the **Majlis al-Shura and municipal council members** who can raise it; the **walis and tribal sheikhs**, respected intermediaries with real standing; and, where the state's image is at stake, the **international and UNESCO bodies**. Frame everything respectfully, within the system, around the shared environment and the Sultanate's own values

— never as opposition or confrontation, which have no place and would only fail.

STEP 4: THE COUNCILS, THE TRADITIONAL CHANNELS & THE HERITAGE APPEAL — WORKING RESPECTFULLY WITHIN THE SYSTEM

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but limited, in a top-down Sultanate, so the prize is influence and reconsideration, not overturning.

The Consultative and Traditional Channels

The **consultative councils** — the Majlis al-Shura and municipal councils — are real, if advisory, channels to raise a concern, and the **traditional governance** — the wali system and tribal sheikhs — are respected intermediaries with standing to carry it upward. Raise the concern respectfully through both.

The Assessment and the Heritage Appeal

Major projects must reckon with **environmental impact assessment and Oman's environmental law**, and the **heritage-and-values appeal** — the Sultanate's own celebrated commitment to conservation, heritage, and its national vision — is a lever to invoke, though, as the oryx shows, with honest limits. Press the assessment and appeal to the state's own better commitments.

The International and UNESCO Attention

The **international and UNESCO attention** an image-conscious Sultanate cares about is a real reputational channel — the more so where, as with the oryx, the state risks being seen to betray its own conservation reputation. Pursued together — the consultative and traditional channels, the assessment and heritage appeal, and the international attention — these levers can influence and reconsider, respectfully, within the system.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always respectfully. **For the consultative councils**: here is a concern for the community and the environment to raise. **For the walis and tribal sheikhs**: here is a matter to carry upward through the traditional channels. **For the environment authority**: here is a project whose assessment and law demand scrutiny. **For the state's own values**: here is a project at odds with the conservation and heritage you celebrate. **For the international and UNESCO bodies**: here is a reputation the Sultanate values, at stake. **The golden rule**: work respectfully within the system, raise the concern through the councils and traditional channels, invoke the state's own values and image, and hold honest expectations — never confront.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a Sultanate with no protest culture, and largely through respectful and international channels. Frame any attention around **the Sultanate's own values and image**: a project at odds with the conservation and heritage Oman celebrates, and the international reputation it values — never as opposition or confrontation. Carry it through respectful domestic channels and, where the image is at stake, the international and UNESCO attention. A few cautions govern everything: keep it respectful and within-system; appeal to the state's own commitments; avoid anything confrontational; and let the

assessment, the heritage, and the international attention carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message respectful, within-system, and appealing to the state's own values.

8A — To a Majlis al-Shura or municipal council member: raise the concern for the community and environment, respectfully.

8B — To a wali or tribal sheikh: ask this respected intermediary to carry the concern upward.

8C — To the environment authority: request scrutiny of the project's assessment under Oman's environmental law.

8D — On the heritage appeal: set out how the project departs from the Sultanate's own conservation and national-vision commitments.

8E — To UNESCO or an international body: flag the reputational stake, where a protected place or the Sultanate's image is at risk.

8F — On the assessment: press the environmental study's rigour and conditions.

8G — To the community: coordinate the concern respectfully and within the system.

8H — On the international attention: engage the image-conscious Sultanate's care for its conservation reputation.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify who decides the project — a ministry or the top; document the harm and the assessment; identify the state's own values it strains. **The fastest-moving levers:** the consultative and traditional channels, and the heritage-and-international appeal. **Emergency action:** raise the concern respectfully through a council member or a wali, and — where a protected place or the state's image is at stake — engage UNESCO and the international attention. Throughout, work within the system, appeal to the state's better commitments, and hold honest expectations.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted decisively toward the top: the state decides the great questions, and will override even its own conservation for oil, as the oryx proved. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not overturning from below, but influence, reconsideration, and the invoking of the state's own values. Lean on the levers the system provides: the consultative and traditional channels, the assessment, the heritage appeal, and the international attention an image-conscious state cares about. And accept the honest limits — the councils advise but do not command, the ultimate power is the Sultan's, and the appeal to values can be overridden — while still working respectfully within the system.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL OVERRIDE — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the challenge is less hidden corruption than open override from the top, as when the oryx sanctuary was cut by royal decree for oil. Respond only through the respectful, within-system channels: the

consultative councils, the traditional walis and sheikhs, the environmental assessment, the heritage appeal, and the international and UNESCO attention. Never through confrontation, which has no place. **On safety:** Oman is a stable, orderly Sultanate; the risk here is not the physical danger of the harshest states, but there is no culture of protest and no space for open opposition, so the work must be respectful, within the system, and consultative, never confrontational. Work through the councils, the traditional channels, and the appeal to the state's own values, and protect those involved by keeping everything respectful and within-system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, respectfully and within the system. The documented harm feeds the council and traditional appeals, the assessment, and the heritage-and-international appeal at once; the community's concern is carried upward through the walis and sheikhs; any attention appeals to the state's own values and image. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and identify who decides and which values it strains; **months two to six**, raise it through the councils and traditional channels, press the assessment, and invoke the heritage and international attention; **beyond**, sustain the respectful appeal for reconsideration. The core discipline: respectful, within-system, consultative, and appealing to the state's better commitments.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Oman is a stable, top-down Sultanate, and this guide does not pretend otherwise — the oryx sanctuary, cut by royal decree for oil and struck from the World Heritage List, is the honest proof. It does not claim a community can overturn a decision made from the top, or that the appeal to the state's values cannot be overridden, or that there is any culture of open opposition — none of that is true. What it claims is narrower and real: that the consultative councils and the traditional wali and tribal channels can carry a concern respectfully upward; that major projects must reckon with the environmental assessment and Oman's environmental law; that the Sultanate's own celebrated commitment to conservation and heritage is a lever to invoke, with honest limits; and that the international and UNESCO attention an image-conscious state values is a real reputational channel. The levers are respectful, within-system, and limited, and the prize is a project raised, assessed, reconsidered, or improved, and the state's own values invoked — not a decision overturned from below. For a consultative Sultanate that prizes stability, heritage, and its own image, that respectful work — within the system, appealing to its better commitments, and with honest expectations — is not a lesser ambition. It is the realistic and appropriate one.